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Mass. ballot: half empty or half full?

Referenda to the fore with so few races contested

By Emma Platoff and Chris Van Buskirk
GLOBE STAFF

For all the excitement elsewhere on the political map, Massachusetts will indeed have its own nail-biter races on Election Day. Just not the ones with candidates.

In a state that routinely hosts some of the nation's least competitive elections, this fall's ballot offers voters a huge range of choice through a record-tying number of ballot questions on everything from tax policy to gun control and the legality of recreational cannabis.

Massachusetts voters have never seen a longer slate of ballot questions than they will on Tuesday, and the often dense explanations require voters to carefully parse their options. Doing your civic duty may feel like taking a final exam. But while the contents for governor, attor-

QUESTIONS, Page A11

'I'm sort of amazed at how much deeper the emotions are running.'

VAL MARIER, *a Democrat in Maine*

Inflation, war, and Trump: a potent mix for midterm voters

The quality of some candidates — or lack of — adds another wild card

By Sam Brodey, Jim Puzzanghera, and Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

WELLS, Maine — Over the last few months in this corner of Maine — as in so many parts of so many states — the toll of this 2026 midterm campaign can be easily measured.

Dozens of political mailers arriving in voters' mailboxes each week. Attack ads filling every TV commercial break. A handful of spam fund-raising texts or emails pinging each day.

For many fatigued voters in Maine, a state whose contest between Republican Senator Susan Collins and Democrat Troy Jackson could determine next year's Senate majority, the number that increasingly seems to matter most is the countdown to Tuesday, when this election will finally come to a close.

Fierce campaigns are hardly new in Maine, or most anywhere else. But voters told the Globe that something felt different about this cycle.

There have been strong feelings about elections before, but "not like this," said Val Marier, 84, a Democrat who dropped off her absentee ballot at the clerk's office in this town on Maine's southern coast.

ELECTION, Page A10

At MIT, a surprising rebuttal to AI use

Proposal to use it in surveillance sparks protest

By Yogev Toby
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

What happens when you train the all-seeing eye of artificial intelligence on one of the very places and people that helped bring the technology into the mainstream?

It turns out even members of the faculty at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology have qualms about how, and how far, AI should be used as a surveillance tool on the Cambridge campus.

When administrators considered adding AI capabilities to campus surveillance cameras to detect criminal activity, a number of faculty — including experts on the uses of computer technology — were so alarmed they schemed over what kind of message to send to the administration. But in keeping with the quirky culture on campus, they didn't stage a sit-in or protest march, but a whimsical bit of pranking aimed at outwitting the AI brain.

Once a week since summer, professors have roamed the campus to adorn security cameras with colorful, glitzy rhinestones and googly eyes. Unlike the more pointed sabotage by some activists to disable the Flock cameras that have generated so much controversy, the so-called white hat hacking at MIT is ultimately benign: the "bedazzling" doesn't interfere with the operation of the cameras.

"We had to come up with another way of having a more

MIT, Page B10



MELECK ELDAHSHOURY FOR THE BOSTON GLOB

Main Street makeover widens a civic divide

Project to spruce up Northampton becomes another flashpoint for political argument

Above, the stretch in front of Northampton City Hall shows the convergence issues — bike riders, dog walkers, and cars jockey for space.

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

NORTHAMPTON — Anna Bowen, who owns Strada Shoes on Main Street, recently spent half an hour helping a customer find the perfect fit, but as she was about to pay, the woman pulled the shoebox back. First, she wanted to know Bowen's position on Picture Main Street, a controversial $43 million project to redesign downtown.

Was Bowen "bike-friendly"?

"I threaded the needle," Bowen recalled. "I told her I was excited, but I was very nervous.'"

Bowen made the sale, but she hasn't forgotten the implied threat: Support Picture Main Street, or else.

Jackhammers are still a ways off, but the touted "once-in-a-generation opportunity" to modernize Main Street has already torn the city apart. That's because a lot more is at stake than a half-mile of asphalt. This struggle is for the very soul of this quirky college town, and it poses an existential question for our online age: What, and who, is Main Street for?

The clash isn't as simple as cyclists versus drivers, or people who embrace change versus those who fight it. It's also about New Englanders who resent being told what's good for

NORTHAMPTON, Page A8



Daylight saving time ended at 2 a.m. Turn your clocks back an hour.

No breaking the fall

Sunday: Sunny, beautiful. High 57-62. Low 48-53.

Monday: Heating up again. High 69-74. Low 51-56.

Complete report, C22.

Representative Ayanna Pressley, Pulitzer-winning journalist Ellen Goodman, and Nobel-winning economist Claudia Goldin reflect on Gloria Steinem's influence in the Globe Magazine's Women & Power 2026.

The Asian American experience can be hard to find on stages throughout the Boston area. **Art + Life, N1.**

The New England Aquarium comes to life long before the visitors arrive. **Travel, N13.**

Charlestown High School could close under a plan being considered by BPS. **Metro, B1.**

Cities vowed to reinvent themselves but created playgrounds for the super rich and pushed out everyone else. **Ideas, K1.**

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**Additional fees may be assessed for borrowers with credit scores lower than 720 and/or cash-out refinance loans.
¹Fixed market rate at time of conversion; one time conversion fee required.